



Instead of competing with the frenetic crowds at Har Ki Pauri, Pilibhit House in Haridwar leverages one valuable luxury commodity: privacy

says Tarun Gulati, Director, VILEEN Rishikesh. “Traditionally, wellness retreats have catered to people who can step away from their routines for weeks at a time. We felt there was an equally important audience that was being overlooked—working professionals in their 30s and 40s, balancing careers, family, and everyday responsibilities.”

The hotel’s philosophy, adds Gulati, is rooted in the Himalayan way of life—combining regional yoga traditions, Ganga-side meditation, Ayurvedic cuisine, nature immersion and Vedic wisdom into a holistic experience. Rather than offering wellness as a temporary indulgence, guests are introduced to a lifestyle they can embrace long after they leave.

The hospitality industry’s

AT A GLANCE

\$6.3

TRILLION

Global wellness economy in 2023, projected to reach \$9 trillion by 2028

\$1.4

TRILLION

Expected value of global wellness tourism market by 2028

19%

Growth in pilgrimage travel in FY25, alongside rising demand for premium stays

Top 12

India’s global ranking in wellness tourism; 5th in the Asia-Pacific region

SOURCE MINISTRY OF TOURISM

enthusiasm is also being reinforced by government investment. India now ranks among the world’s leading wellness tourism markets, while spiritual circuits centered on destinations such as Varanasi, Ayodhya, Haridwar, Bodh Gaya, and Kurukshetra are being bolstered by infrastructure upgrades, improved connectivity, and tourism promotion. The Ministry of Tourism ranks India 12th among the world’s top wellness tourism markets and fifth in Asia-Pacific for wellness destinations.

INTRIGUING PARADOX

Yet the Moksha economy presents an intriguing paradox. Can spirituality be curated without becoming commodified? Does exclusivity dilute experiences rooted in accessibility and faith?

Hospitality executives argue that they are not commercialising spirituality but improving access to it. Their role, they contend, is to remove logistical friction—crowds, queues, transport, and planning—allowing guests to engage more deeply with India’s living traditions. The experience, they insist, remains authentic; only its delivery has become more thoughtful.

Be that as it may, India’s competitive advantage lies not merely in luxury infrastructure but in intangible cultural assets accumulated over millennia. Beaches, ski resorts, and city hotels can be replicated almost anywhere. The Ganges at dusk, soulful chants echoing through an ancient temple, Himalayan silence or the philosophical legacy of the Bhagavad Gita cannot. **BT**